

HOW TO SPEAK *English* FLUENTLY



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Chapter 1: Introduction

Have you been learning English for a long time but still struggle to understand native English speakers? Have you been taking English classes for years but do not see much progress in your English speaking abilities? Do you get nervous and make mistakes when you have to speak English with other people? Do you get confused and overwhelmed when listening to people talk in English?

This book was designed to teach you:

How to make specific goals related to your English learning.

- Tips to improve your speaking, listening, reading and writing skills in English.

What resources are available to help you learn English in your own time.

It is frustrating to be studying English and not see results. You deserve to learn why you may not be seeing results and what you can do to see your English language skills improve.

There are so many classes, teachers, books and websites that try to give you advice that is “the best way to learn English” In this book you will learn that only you know the best way you learn.

In this book, I will provide you with many different ideas, tips and resources that you will find helpful and will be able to use and try right away.

Why do you want to speak English fluently?

Each person has a different reason as to why they want to speak English fluently or proficiently. Some many want a better job and others may want to travel or make new friends. No matter what your reason for learning to speak English is, you need to commit to learning English.

There is no magic formula or method to make you learn English in a day. You need to set a goal and stick to how you plan to improve your English language skills.

Since each person has different goals, some of the methods in this book will not work for you while others will. The most important thing is that you try. Not that you try once in a while to improve your English but that you commit to 10, 15 or 30 minutes a day to improving your English.

This book is very practical and highly actionable. You will find many links and ideas within that will help you find a way that helps you improve your English. My goal is to help you speak better English by giving you different tips, tricks, resources and ideas.

Chapter 2: Five Limiting Beliefs about Learning English

Many people have beliefs that limit their language learning. It hinders their learning because they think they can't learn English because of the belief or thought that they keep telling themselves over and over again.

Below you will read about five common limiting beliefs that students that are learning (or want to learn) English have.

Many people say...

1. I'm too old to learn English.

You are never too old to learn something new. It is not true that there is an age limit for learning a new language. It may however, be more difficult as time goes on but you're up for a challenge, right? Instead of making up excuses of what you aren't learning, keep track of what you know or have learned. You could try to learn one new word a day, write a paragraph a day or spend 10 minutes focusing on English. If you take small steps to learning English; you will learn. Make a list of words you know or just learned. Don't get stuck on what you don't know. The more positive you are about your learning and English language acquisition, the better it will stick in your mind.

2. I can't speak English proficiently without traveling.

This is not true. I have met a lot (like thousands) of people that speak proficient English and they have never traveled to any English speaking country. They speak and understand English. You too can learn English without jetting off to New York, Sydney or London. Instead of focusing on what you can't do right now, focus on what you can. You can learn English where you live if you have access to a computer and are determined. There are plenty of free resources, websites and classes on the internet that can help teach you English.

3. I have no one to speak English with.

That's ok! You can learn to speak English no matter where you live in the world as long as you have access to a computer. It doesn't matter if you live in a remote village in the mountains of India or in the jungle in the middle of South America. You can find other English learners, just like you online that want to learn English and would love to practice speaking with you. Many people are in the same situation as you are. There are many language exchange and language learning websites that will connect you to someone that wants to practice English or that wants to learn your native language. With the advances in technology, you can literally learn to speak English without ever leaving your home.

4. I can't remember all of the English grammar rules.

No one can remember all the grammar rules. Learning a new language is not about learning rules, it is about learning words that allow you to communicate with other people. Your grammar does not need to be perfect or even near perfect to be understood and start communicating. Native English speakers do not know all (or often times a lot) of grammar rules and make many grammar mistakes. They don't care. I assume that since you are reading this book you want to learn to speak English fluently. Focus on speaking and listening not on being the English grammar police.

Let's pretend your grammar isn't great but you try speaking anyway. You could say 'I yesterday banana eat.' And I as a native speaker might say back to you, 'Oh, you mean... you ate a banana yesterday?' At that point, if you were paying attention you would have heard what you were trying to say, stated correctly and could rephrase (or resay) what you heard. 'Yes, I ate a banana yesterday.' Just like that, you were able to communicate with someone while making grammar mistakes and learn the correct way to say something.... without studying a grammar book or rules about past tense. You can drastically improve your English grammar by practicing speaking.

Stop wasting your time memorizing verb tenses and grammar rules. This will not help you become a better English speaker. It instead will make you insecure about speaking because you are thinking about rules instead of thinking about talking and communicating with a new person.

5. I'm afraid to make mistakes.

Mistakes are good; no...EXCELLENT! The more mistakes you make the faster and more you will learn. Everyone makes mistakes all the time. You should try not to get hung up on feeling bad about making mistakes.

In my class, I had two very different students. One never said anything and if I forced her to speak she would look really nervous and whisper her answer. She was obviously terrified that something bad could happen from her mistakes.

Another student that was in the same classroom talked a lot (sometimes too much). His English was far from perfect but he kept trying. He made a lot of mistakes but everyday kept trying his best and approached learning English as a positive and fun thing. He liked that he could communicate and talk to more people.

The difference between these two students is that one was terrified of making mistakes and the other did his best. By trying your best and focusing on learning more, you will learn English. If you focus on the negative, like telling yourself that you don't know how to say something or that people will laugh at you if you pronounce something wrong, you are hindering or stopping your learning.

Going Forward...

Stop making excuses and telling yourself that you can't learn English. Learning to speak English is something that is totally possible and realistic. You just need to approach your language learning in a positive manner and stop your negative thoughts.

Chapter 3: Your Mindset

Did you know that your thoughts directly influence how successfully you learn English?

What is your mindset? Mindset is the attitude or disposition that you have towards something.

Negative Mindset & Fear

Imagine that you are trying to learn English. Every time you go to English class, you don't participate because you think you can't learn. Every time someone says something to you in English, you say "I don't understand." Every time you think about learning English you get nervous or anxious and think negative thoughts like 'this is too hard' or 'I will never learn to speak English fluently.'

Many English language learners have this exact problem. They have so many negative thoughts about learning English that they set themselves up for failure. When you have a negative mindset or are afraid to do something, you make up constant excuses of why you can't or won't do something. You start to convince yourself that your excuses are true.

If you are fearful, you have unpleasant feelings and feel threatened or like you are in danger.

When you have a negative mindset or are fearful of something you can have some physical symptoms as well. You may try to avoid going to class, doing your homework or participating. You may get headaches or stomach aches before or when you have to learn English. You may also feel nervous or anxious about specific things.

When I was learning my second language in a classroom, I would physically get a stomach ache and try to disappear (it never worked) when I knew it was going to be my turn to speak or answer a question. I wanted to avoid being there all together, but I had no option since it was a required course.

If you continue to have a negative mindset, you will probably not learn to speak English fluently. If you continue to be negative and fearful you will continue to fail and you will not see many advances in your English language acquisition.

Don't let your negative feelings determine what you do in life. Think about what you need to do in English...

Do a presentation

Write a paper

Make a phone call

Have a conversation with your professor

Go to a job interview

These don't seem like such scary tasks, do they? Ask yourself: What's the worst thing that could happen? Why am I fearful? What is making me scared?

Most likely the worst things that could happen if you do one of these tasks are: you could get confused and not understand, you could make mistakes or errors or you could forget what you are supposed to say.

Once you identify what is making you nervous or feel negative about learning English, you can start to solve your problem.

If you make a mistake, the worst thing that could happen is that you get laughed at, have to repeat yourself or lose points on your assignment. No one will hurt you or belittle you if you make a mistake when speaking English.

Next time you find yourself feeling negative about learning English or doing something in English, ask yourself: 'What's the worst thing that could happen?' This should help you work through your fear and negative mindset.

Positive Mindset

Being optimistic and looking at the positive side of things can improve your chances of learning English fluently.

Positive thinking can help you learn to speak English faster. When you are positive or excited about something you feel good. This is how you should feel when you are learning and studying English.

Four Steps to Helping You Keep a Positive Mindset:

1. Small Successes

Instead of focusing on the big picture of “learning to speak English fluently” focus on small attainable mini habits or goals. If you are able to focus on one thing at a time, you will feel more successful and will be able to accomplish more.

For example: You could focus on learning how to say five phrases about what you did yesterday. This way, once you memorize five phrases you will feel accomplished; like you actually did something versus trying to learn all the past tense verbs at the same time.

Don't focus on what you can't do or haven't done. Stay positive and focus on what you have learned.

2. Do Your Best

Always do your best. Try not to compare your language speaking skills to other people. This is hard but if you focus on doing your best and speaking as much English as you can, you will learn faster.

If you focus on others, you will have trouble focusing on your goals. You will always be comparing your English to someone else which is not very productive. It's ok to make mistakes but know that you did the best you could. If you think that you can't do it or that it is too hard, it will be more difficult to achieve your goals.

3. Try Your Hardest

Trying you hardest will help you learn English quicker. It is not always easy to try your hardest, sometimes you are tired, or have other things on your mind but you need to focus on what you are doing in the moment. By focusing on one thing at a time and giving it 100 percent, you will feel better and see your results

quicker.

That means if you decide that you are going to listen to 10 minutes of English speaking a day, you need to stop everything else for those 10 minutes. Turn off your phone, find a quiet place without distractions and try your hardest for 10 minutes to focus on improving your English listening skills.

If you let things distract you, you will not be able to concentrate and try your hardest to learn. If you cannot try your hardest because you are distracted, you will not see the results you want to see.

4. Be positive

Being positive is easier for some people than for others. Smile, think positive thoughts, think how it will feel to speak fluent English, think about meeting and achieving your English language goals. The more positive your outlook and thoughts are about learning and practicing English, the better you will feel.

Chapter 4: Goals

It is estimated that more than 2 billion people are trying to learn English worldwide and you are one of them. The problem is that most will not succeed to become fluent in English because they do not set goals.

You want to be successful, right? Saying you want to speak English fluently is not good enough. This is a very broad statement. When you say something like, 'I want to learn English' it is very hard to measure if you are successful or not.

In order to learn English fluently and successfully, you need to set specific goals related to your language learning.

Think about what your end goal is...

Do you want to travel to the United States or UK?

Do you want to get a job where you speak English every day?

Do you want to pass the IELTS, TOEIC or TOEFL exam?

Do you want to make English speaking friends?

Before you set a goal, you need to decide on one final goal that you would like to achieve.

Example Goals:

Learn English so I can get a job at a hotel.

Travel around the United States for one month.

Pass the IELTS exam the first time I take it.

Now, these goals are okay but they need to be more specific.

By creating a S.M.A.R.T., goal you will be able to create a specific goal that in turn will give you the steps you need to achieve it.

S.M.A.R.T. goal stands for:

Specific, **M**easurable, **A**ttainable, **R**elevant and **T**ime-Bound **Specific** goals help you answer: who, what, where, when and why?

Who will meet the goal?

What is your goal?

What do you need to do to meet the goal?

When will you meet your goal by?

Where/How will you meet this goal?

What resources do you need?

Why is this an important goal?

Which actions will you take to meet the goal?

It is important to set a date to know when you need to complete your goal by.

This will help you create a plan or timeline.

Measurable goals are concrete and specific. You will be able to measure your

actions and know if you successfully met your goal.

Attainable goals will be something that you can physically or mentally do within the time restraints. It should be a goal that is achievable.

Relevant goals help you evaluate if they are specific to what you want to achieve.

Time-Bound goals have an end or finish date. You will know if you met your goal by the specific date that you set.

Examples of S.M.A.R.T. Goals Related to English Learning:

Example 1:

I will listen to 15 minutes of English podcasts every day from January 1 to March 31. I will keep track each day of how many minutes I listened to in my phone's calendar.

Example 2:

I will attend an English conversation group at my university every week for 3 months. I will talk to three different people at each conversation group. I will keep track of the dates I attended and who I talked to in my English notebook.

Example 3:

I will read one book in English every week for a year. I will take notes on new words or concepts I learned in my notebook. I will also write down the title of each book.

Example 4:

I will do a language exchange for two hours each week for six months. I will teach the person my language for one hour and they will teach me theirs for one hour. I will record what I learned in a document on my computer.

Example 5:

I will learn one new word in English every day for a month. I will make a list of the new words I learned and their meanings in a notebook.

Chapter 5: Reevaluate How You Are Learning English

The quickest way to improve your English and become a proficient or fluent speaker is by speaking.

Memorizing grammar and verb tenses will not help you become fluent in English quickly. Knowing a lot of English grammar will help you speak better (or more correct) English but it won't increase your fluency.

If you have been studying English for a long time but can't speak or have trouble understanding native English speakers then you need to think about how you are learning.

Are you learning English the best way for you?

Most people start learning a language in school or at a language institute or class. Many times people do not see the progress they would like to see and become disappointed and think that they can't learn English. This is not true.

The old fashioned way of studying a textbook and doing grammar exercises does not work for everyone. Actually, very few people learn to speak a language successfully with this model.

It can get confusing because no matter whom you talk to or where you look on the internet there are different ways to learn English. Some programs guarantee proficiency or fluency, whereas others are topic specific and will help you improve one skill area. No one can decide what is best for you; especially someone that doesn't even know you. You must decide which course of study will make the greatest impact on your life.

In order to learn English, you need to know how you learn best. Ask yourself the following questions:

- Do I like to go to a class, have a tutor online or do self-guided learning?
- Do I learn best from audio, videos or reading?

- What do I need to be able to do in English? (Speak to native speakers? Pass an exam? Get a job? Etc.)

How much time do I have to learn English each day? Week? Month?

- Do I have the time or financial means to travel or live abroad in an English speaking country?

Learning a new language can be difficult but remember you can do it. Everyone learns differently but I can tell you that you learned to speak a language well at least once in your life. That's your native language.

When you were a baby and a young child learning to speak your native language (be it, Spanish, Portuguese, Russian, Arabic, etc.) your mother and father did not teach you to speak by taking out books and making you study lists of words.

You learned to speak your native language naturally. You learned by making mistakes. This is how everyone learns to speak. You learn by mimicking or copying what you hear and then saying it back again. Small children make many mistakes when they are learning to speak their first language. This is great. No one is perfect and everyone learns from their mistakes.

Maybe you have been going to an English class in your city.

Maybe you have been using a textbook or CD's to learn English. Whatever you have been doing, try doing something different. Try learning English in a new or different way.

You may not be experiencing success because you are learning English in the wrong way for you. There is no one special way to learn a language. You need to try different methods out and find out what works best for you.

Challenge yourself to learn English differently.

Take Action:

1. Evaluate how you learn something best. What is the best way for you to improve your English language speaking?
2. Pick one new method that you can do to learn or improve your English.
(For example: watch TV in English, listen to podcasts, find an online native English tutor, etc.)

Chapter 6: Language as a Tool Not a Science

Learning a new language should not be about formulating equations of verb + adverb + noun + subject = perfect sentence.

That's the wrong approach to learning English. Learning English should not seem like rocket science. It should be fun, easy and enjoyable if you are learning the right way for you.

No matter how much grammar you learn it won't drastically improve your English fluency. I remember when I was learning my second language, my teacher made me memorize lists of words, verb charts and grammar rules. This was not fun for me. I hated it. I thought I would never or couldn't learn a new language because it was so difficult. Learning this way made me so nervous and scared to speak.

Don't focus on the wrong things. Memorizing lists of words and grammar rules won't help you be a better English speaker, it will just make you grammar rule crazy. If the way you are learning English does not feel right to you, make some changes.

Plus... I have a secret for you. Guess what? Most native speakers make a lot of grammar mistakes and they keep on talking. They don't even know or care about their mistakes.

After learning a language for six years the traditional way (in a classroom), I couldn't have a conversation with a native speaker. I was terrified to speak. I couldn't understand. All I could really do was name off random vocabulary words and recite dialogues that I memorized.

When I was forced to use my second language, I couldn't. I was stuck thinking about verb tenses and grammar and I couldn't concentrate on communicating with someone.

The purpose of learning a new language is so that you can communicate with

more people. If you speak English fluently, you will be able to make new friends, talk to people, carry on conversations, ask questions and understand when someone speaks with you. The purpose of learning a new language is not to be a grammar expert, at least not in my opinion. If you learn perfect grammar it doesn't mean you are fluent. It doesn't even mean you can carry on a basic conversation. All being a 'grammar expert' means is that you are able to conjugate verbs without errors.

I bet you rarely think about different aspects of grammar when you are speaking your native language. So, why are you trying to make English so difficult?

Try using English as a tool. A tool that helps you investigate things that you are interested in; a tool that helps you communicate.

If you are interested in music, there is a plethora of information on this topic.

Not only can you "google" the information in English but you can find websites, podcasts or online communities or forums that revolve around the things you are interested in.

Chapter 7: Improve Your Speaking

You will not learn to speak English in one day but the more you practice the better you will get.

Many people think that they can't become better speakers without traveling or living in an English speaking country. This is not true. There are opportunities in most places in the world and online that will allow you to practice your speaking skills without ever leaving your city.

There are also other things that influence whether you learn to speak English fluently or not.

Mistakes

Many English language learners are afraid to talk. Why? Because they don't know the correct words to say or they are afraid they will say the wrong verb.

Don't be one of these people. Don't be ashamed into thinking that mistakes are bad.

You can't get better at something without making mistakes and trying. The more mistakes that you make the better you will get. Making a lot of mistakes will also let you learn quicker.

If you are silent and scared to speak then you will not get better at speaking English. You will spend time thinking about English.

If you just open your mouth and speak, you will talk a lot. You will get practice and you will make mistakes. You will learn what changes you need to make so that native English speakers can understand you better.

If you decide to speak English instead of being silent, you will feel more successful. You will feel more successful because you are taking action, though challenging and working towards your goal of speaking fluent English.

Think about something that you are good at. Did you learn to do it in a day? In a week? Did you have to try over and over again to get good at it? Did you make mistakes before you learned the right way to do it?

If you find just diving into speaking right away difficult, try slowly increasing the amount you talk. For example, if you go to English class you could count how many times you participate or talk in each class. If you only spoke one time in your first class, try speaking two times in the next class. In each class, try to talk a little more. Over time it will get easier.

Finding Someone to Speak English With

Do you struggle to learn English because you have no one to speak to? This should not be your excuse. There are billions of people learning to speak English that would be eager to practice speaking with you.

Online you can find people to practice English with on many websites. Below you will find a list of websites where you can talk to or correspond with other people learning English and/or your language.

My Language Exchange (<http://www.mylanguageexchange.com/>)

iTalki (<http://www.italki.com/hl/en-us>)

Conversation Exchange (<http://www.conversationexchange.com/>)

Interpals (<http://www.interpals.net/>)

LingoGlobe (<http://www.lingoglobe.com/>)

Easy Language Exchange (<http://www.easylanguageexchange.com/>)

Verbling (<https://www.verbling.com/>)

Tongue Out (<http://tongueout.net/>)

Coeffee (<http://en.coffee.com/>)

Duolingo (<https://www.duolingo.com/>)

Busuu (<http://www.busuu.com/enc/>)

Language Exchange Project <http://languageexchange.gregloby.com/>

Make an Audio or Video Journal

Every day you could record yourself speaking about your day or topic. This would allow you to practice speaking and you could play back the recordings to see how you are improving over time. Even making a goal of speaking for one minute a day can help you improve over time.

Memorize phrases not words

When you are learning a new language, it is sometimes difficult to know what to focus on. Many people focus on memorizing lists of words in the new language. This is not a good practice.

Instead try memorizing phrases or sentence stems that are meaningful to you. So,

phrases that you will use often or more than once.
For example: Yesterday, I went to school.

After memorizing this you can insert more words to change the meaning.

Yesterday, I went to work.

Yesterday, I went to the store.

Yesterday, I went to the beach.

Yesterday, I went to a restaurant.

You could also change the beginning of the sentence.

Last week , I went to school.

Last month , I went to school.

Last year , I went to school.

When I was 10 years old , I went to school.

A long time ago , I went to school.

By memorizing entire phrases that are useful to your learning, you will be able to speak faster. You will also build a small toolbox that you can refer to whenever you get stuck or can't think of something to say.

Take Action:

1. Find someone to speak English to
2. Talk more
3. Don't be afraid to make mistakes
4. Memorize one new phrase or sentence starter a day

Chapter 8: Improve Your Listening

Are you good at writing and reading in English but struggle to understand native speakers? This is very common. In order to develop your listening skills you need to take time to immerse yourself in English.

There are many different activities you can do to improve your English listening skill. Remember, you won't understand everything you hear. That's okay. At the beginning you may only understand 20 or 30% of what you hear in English. Don't panic. Focus on the words you do understand and try to understand the overall meaning of what you are listening to.

After training your ears to understand English, you will start to understand more and more. It is not a super quick process. It takes time and effort on your part. Just keep listening. You will start to understand more and more words and soon only have a few things you understand.

Below you will find different suggested activities that you could do to help you improve your English speaking.

Listen to Podcasts

Podcasts are audio (and sometimes video files) that you can download for free. Since you can download them, you can put them on your iPod, smartphone or listen to them in your computer.

Many English learners only listen to podcasts about learning English. This is a mistake! There are many wonderful podcasts about thousands of subjects. Listen to podcasts that are of interest to you. Take some time to go through the different

categories on iTunes and try listening to a few different podcasts.

Many people have their podcasts transcribed or written for their audience and available to download for free on their website. The transcript can help you follow along to the audio file while you listen to the podcast. It will also help you better understand what the person in the podcast is saying because you will be able to hear and read at the same time.

Watch the News in English

Many people have habit of watching the news in their native language. By watching the news in English, you can stay informed and improve your English listening skills at the same time.

Many of the top news stories have short video clips that you can watch; usually under a minute.

One of the benefits of watching the news is that the broadcasters speak a few clear and basic English. So, it should be easier to understand because they do not use slang or colloquial phrases when presenting the news.

Websites with Stories

TV/Movies

Watching TV or movies is great way to increase your English listening comprehension. You also can turn on the subtitles on many TV programs and movies and read as you watch the movie. This will help improve your comprehension of what you are watching.

Listen to Music in English

YouTube is a great resource for listening to music in English you can also find many songs with the lyrics on the video.

To find the song lyrics you are looking for you can search in google or YouTube: Song + lyrics.

Other website such as **Lyrics.com** and **azlyrics.com**

thousands of lyrics available for free.

By listening to a song while reading the lyrics you will be able to identify (read) words that you didn't understand as they were being sung. You can also use the lyrics to help you learn new vocabulary and natural sentence structures or expressions.

Music will also help you sing or speak faster in English. When I was learning my second language, I listened to a lot of music. I would listen to some songs over and over again. I would sing along and do the best I could. Sometimes the song was way too fast for me to say and I would get tongue tied but the more I listened and practiced singing along the better I got at it.

Chapter 9: Improve Your Reading

Many people that are trying to learn to speak English are good at reading. This may be the case for you and it may not be. It is important to improve your English reading skills, as well as you speaking and listening skills.

News & Newspapers

You can read the news in English on many sites.

Some countries have English language newspapers available-if that is something you can access in your country

One nice feature on Google is you can set it up to email you updates or alerts about news from certain topics. So, if you want to receive email about your country, a football team or a celebrity, you could set it up so that it emails you each day with any relevant news in English about that topic. You can sign up for Google News Alerts here. <http://www.google.com/alerts>

Books and Magazines

You can buy books or find books at libraries, thrift markets or specialty stores. Most children's books in English are wonderful and the illustrations can help you improve your understanding of what you are reading.

You can access some magazines and their websites for free, others have paid subscriptions and you can receive or access a monthly or weekly magazine via a password protected website.

Blogs

There are millions, if not billions of blogs on the internet. Most are centered on one main topic. You could spend 10 or 15 minutes a day reading blogs about subjects that interest you.

Instead of only reading blogs that are for English learners, try following blogs that are about subjects that interest you. You shouldn't get bored with your English language learning. Find websites that you like and increase your vocabulary and understanding of English while learning something new.

Kindle's Free Books

You do not have to have a kindle or e-reader device to download and read kindle books for free.

Since you are reading this book, you probably already know how to access books on Amazon but if not I will explain below.

There are downloadable apps for most devices (phones, computers and tablets) that have access to the internet. You can read and download books to this app without having to buy a kindle e-reader.

Within the Amazon store, there is a section for free books. Some books are always free and others are free for a short time period, usually lasting 1-5 days. There is a great variety of genre or types of books that you can download for free. In addition to 'free' books, Amazon has millions of books available for a nominal price. Many books are available for under \$5.

Chapter 10: Improve Your Writing

The best way to improve your writing is by writing! You can't get better at it if you never do it.

Write in a Journal Every Day

Try writing in a journal every day. You could write what you did that day, what you're going to do the next day or how you are feeling.

Though this may sound simple, over time you will be able to write even more and many sentences and verb tenses will become more natural to use.

Write a Story

Yes, I know you aren't a little kid but anyone can write a story. Your story doesn't need to be complicated nor 5 or 50 pages long. You can write a simple short story in less than a page.

Writing a fictional story allows you to use your imagination and be creative. You could write about something silly or serious or anything at all.

Keep your writing simple:

When you are writing in a new language you might try to write say way you do in your native language. Don't! By translating phrases from your native language to English, you most likely will use phrases that do not sound natural in English.

Try to keep your writing simple. Keep your sentences simple and try to get to the point quickly. By writing short simple sentences in English, your readers will be able to better understand you. You will also avoid punctuation mistakes if you keep your sentences short.

Read Your Writing Out Loud:

Reading something 'out loud' means that you read in an audible voice to yourself or someone else. Reading what you have written out loud will allow you to hear mistakes. Your eyes may not see errors but if you take time to read each sentence out loud you will hear some errors.

You don't always have to write a story. You could write:

a list (of animals, places, things in your kitchen, etc.)

a letter

a recipe

a thank you note

a to-do list

instructions on how to do something

a complaint letter

your opinion on something

a review of a restaurant, movie or book

Chapter 11: Immerse Yourself in English

When you immerse yourself, you put yourself into something... so, English immersion means you put yourself into an English speaking environment.

There are two ways to immerse yourself in a language, by traveling to another country (USA, UK, Canada, Australia, etc.) or by consciously making an effort to speak English where you live.

Travel:

If you travel or live in an English speaking country you will instantly be immersed into the language.

Basically you will do everything in English. You will go to the store in English.

You will take the public transportation in English. You will ask for direction and make phone calls in English. You will interact with everyone in English.

This may seem a little strange or scary at first but being immersed in a language and culture is an excellent and often quick way to learn a language. Why? Well, you are forced into a fight or flight mode. Which means you can either run home and freak out or try to make sense of the new language and find a way to function.

Living in a new country can be overwhelming at first. Not only do you have to figure out a new language but you have to figure out cultural nuances and differences. Don't worry; it will get easier with time.

At the beginning you might not understand anything or very little. That's normal. Just smile and have a few phrases in English ready; like:

I'm learning English, can you say that again.

I'm sorry, I didn't understand. Can you say that again slower?

Can you show me _____?

Can you write that down?

When people see that you are making an effort to learn English they will often want to help you and be kind. If they're not, don't worry, just continue on to the next person.

Slowly, you will start to hear words or phrases that you recognize. You will make new routines and learn how to ask for the fruits and vegetables you want at the grocery store or order the perfect coffee. It just takes time. These small successes should feel good.

Immersion in a language allows you to learn quickly because you are forced to

understand. You learn that communication is important.

Once you start understanding more and more you will become more comfortable. You will start to take more risks and speak more English. It can be intimidating but don't be afraid. Your English speaking skills won't get better if you don't try. Once you start speaking, you may only answer in one word or short sentences. The important thing is that you are trying your best. As more time goes on, you will feel better, everything won't feel so new and strange and you will be able to communicate with more people and more often.

To ensure your time being immersed in English is successful, follow these seven tips:

1- Make mistakes

The more mistakes you will make the more you will learn. Remember, learning a new language is like being a child again. Don't be afraid to say the wrong thing. Try your best and learn from the mistakes that you do make.

2- Listen for words you know

Try not to get overwhelmed by someone when listening to English. Listen for words or parts of sentences that you do understand and fill in the rest of the gaps.

3- Be flexible

Being flexible is key. If you remember that you are there for the experience. Not every moment in a new country will be fun but if you are flexible and positive; you will make the most out of every situation.

4- Listen/Look for Language Patterns

No one knows everything about a language, especially a foreign language but try using what you do know to hear patterns in speech. You can mimic patterns and listen for rules or repeated things to help you learn the English language quicker.

5- Ask more questions and clarify

If you don't understand something, ask a question or clarify. You can ensure you are not wasting time by just assuming you understood correctly. Repeat back what you heard or say, 'I understood that..... Is that right?' You then give the

person the chance to correct you if you did not understand things correctly the first time.

6- No One Knows Everything

No one is perfect. If you don't understand something or can't figure something out at first that's ok. No one can learn English in a day or a month, but the important thing is that you are improving. Small improvements add up to fluency over time.

7- Circumlocution is Your New Best Friend

When learning English, you might not always have the words you need to say something or express yourself. You may feel stuck and want to give up. DON'T! All you need to do is little circumlocution. Circumlocution is the act of saying something in more words than necessary. So, if you can't think of the exact word in English, instead explain the concept or word until the person knows what you are trying to say.

Example of circumlocution: Pretend you can't think of the word 'circle' in English. I could say it is a shape. It isn't a triangle or a square but it's the shape that clocks and pizzas are. It is round like an orange. Most people should be able to guess that you mean a circle.

Traveling or living abroad is cost restrictive and not everyone can afford to travel. If you have the opportunity or resources to travel to an English speaking country...DO IT! The benefits of traveling abroad are endless.

How can I meet native English speakers when I am traveling or new to a place?

Some people don't have a problem walking up to people and talking to them while others feel more intimidated. There are some groups and organizations that could help you find people that want to meet people that are traveling, or studying a language.

Learn English Where You Live

Don't trick yourself to think that you can't learn English where you live. There are many resources online and in the majority of communities that will help you accomplish your goal of learning to speak English fluently.

In your community you should be able to find other people that want to learn to speak English fluently just like you. You will just have to take time to find these people... but they do exist.

You could look for people that want to improve their English at:

Schools/Universities

Language Institute

Language Exchange/Conversation Groups

There are also English speaking expats in many parts of the world.

Once you find one or two other people that are interested in speaking English with you schedule a time to meet.

Remember, you do not need to sit down for a formal study session. It is best to keep it casual and not too long. You could spend time talking about one specific topic or talking turns asking each other questions. The important thing is that you are practicing English. After meeting one time, you could try to set a reoccurring meeting time, maybe once a week or twice a month.

You could also plan outings or activities 'only in English': maybe bowling, cooking a meal together or playing a game.

You could also try reading a book in English and then discussing the book and your thoughts about it; in an 'English book club'. Don't have access to English books? You can download free books on Amazon.com and you don't need a Kindle to access them.

Chapter 12: Achieving English Fluency

So, many English learners want to be “fluent” but what is English fluency? How will you know if you are fluent in English? Maybe you are already fluent in English.

If you look up ‘fluent’ in the dictionary, it says: to be able to express oneself easily and articulately.

Native English speakers are fluent because English is their first language. It is very hard for English language learners to sound like native English speakers unless they moved to an English speaking country before the age of 10 or have extensive schooling or exposure to native English speakers where they live.

There are different ways to measure fluency. You may find that you are proficient in one type of English but not in another. That is very common.

We will now look at what it means to be ‘proficient’ in social, academic and professional English.

The first type of English that you could become proficient in is in social English or conversational English. The majority of students become proficient in this type of English first.

If you are proficient in social English, you can:

have everyday conversations in English

ask and answer common questions in English

explain something

talk to people and use English in informal settings

ask for directions

- have your basic needs met (get food, housing, other necessities done in English)

use some slang words or common sayings

The second type of English that you could become proficient in is: Academic English. Someone that is proficient in academic English may have attended elementary, high school or university in English. Becoming proficient in academic English takes more time than social English; this is because there is a more complex vocabulary than social English.

Academic English is something that is improved over time for both native and non-native English speakers. Each year in school, you learn more complex academic skills. Even native English speakers have trouble becoming proficient in academic English. Especially since each academic area or subject has its own vocabulary.

If you are proficient in academic English you can:

cite sources/evidence of a claim that you are making

summarize and retell stories or what you heard

paraphrase or rephrase what you have heard

ask questions based on text

compare and contrast ideas

- write in a variety of genres (narrative, descriptive, argumentative, etc.)

analyze stories and author's point of view

identify strengths and weaknesses of texts

The last type of English fluency is Professional English Fluency or proficiency. Professional English is English that you specifically use to carry out the functions of your job or career. Each person will have a different sub set of 'professional fluency'. Lawyers, doctors, engineers, architects and teachers all use a different job specific vocabulary.

It is possible to be proficient in a technical English vocabulary exclusively used in the medical field but have little knowledge of English architectural vocabulary. Each profession has a specific technical vocabulary and each person will develop a different professional vocabulary.

If you are proficient in professional English, you can:

• speak about industry specific problems

- participate in discussions about common topics in your professional realm
- ask and understand questions using technical English vocabulary related to your profession/industry

When it comes to professional vocabulary, you may be 'fluent' in one area and not another. For example: A banker may be able to talk about money, stocks, bonds and investments with ease but can't talk about local and federal laws. The banker will not be able to have a complex conversation about laws because she does not work in this field.

Also, keep in mind that many native English speakers are not proficient in all technical vocabularies. It doesn't matter how educated you are, you will never know everything.

People who are fluent in English can:

1. Speak English all day. Do their normal routine in English.
2. Watch the news or listen to the radio and understand nearly everything.
3. Think in English instead of translating everything
4. Understand English speakers with different accents.
5. Code-Switch
6. Speak English confidently
7. Give a presentation about a topic of your choice in English.
8. Speak on the phone in English.
9. Be understood by native English speakers when speaking English.
10. Dream in English
11. Use clues to help them understand

Many people base how good of English they speak on their English exam scores, but that's a bad idea. Anyone can cram for an exam and pass it. Most exams are not the best indicator of English fluency.

I can't tell you when you are fluent and no one else either. It's up to you to decide when you feel comfortable using English.

Chapter 13: Learning English Fluently Will Change Your Life

The time and effort that it takes to learn to speak English fluently is worth it. It may take you months or years but the ways that speaking English fluently will change your life are priceless.

New frame of reference

Learning to communicate in English fluently will give you a new frame of reference. You will be familiar with a new language, culture and people that are different from your own. You learn how people do and think differently than you are used to.

Having a new frame of reference will help you to make decisions differently. It will allow you to refer to different things you have learned. Learning to speak a new language opens your mind and shows you that anything is possible.

Communicate with more people

By learning to speak English fluently you will be able to communicate with more people. Not just native English speakers but people that use English for work, travel and pleasure.

Since you will be able to speak and relate to more people you may develop new friendships or relationships. The feeling of being able to successfully communicate with someone that you wouldn't have been able to communicate with before is great. You will feel more confident and won't be afraid to make mistakes.

More job/career opportunities

Many people study English with the possibility of bettering their life with better or higher paying jobs or more successful careers. By learning to speak English fluently, you will be a bigger asset to companies that you apply to. Many companies are interested in hiring people that are fluent in more than language. Also, if you already enjoy where you are working, you may be able to get a better paying position or a raise just for speaking English.

Make You More Flexible

People who speak more than one language tend to be more flexible. They know that things can be said, done and interpreted in different ways. By being more flexible, you may have more opportunities to do things or learn new things. You might also be more patient and willing to learn and listen to other people.

Learning a new language helps you become more tolerant of people's differences and more understanding when problems so arise.

Think differently

After learning to speak English fluently, you might have boarded your horizons and learned new information that enables you to think differently. Many people who are bilingual or multilingual are better at solving problems than monolinguals.

Chapter 14: Take Action Today

This book is coming to an end. You should now have some idea, tips and resources to help you improve your English language skills. There were countless ways to improve your English listening, speaking, reading and writing skills.

The best way to actually meet your goals is to take action-don't wait; do it today! You won't achieve your goals if you go nothing. Take a few minutes to evaluate what you would like to accomplish in relation to learning English and then set a S.M.A.R.T. goal and start working towards achieving it.

You have learned what you need to take some action today... even if it's only 5 minutes. Start now!

THE END